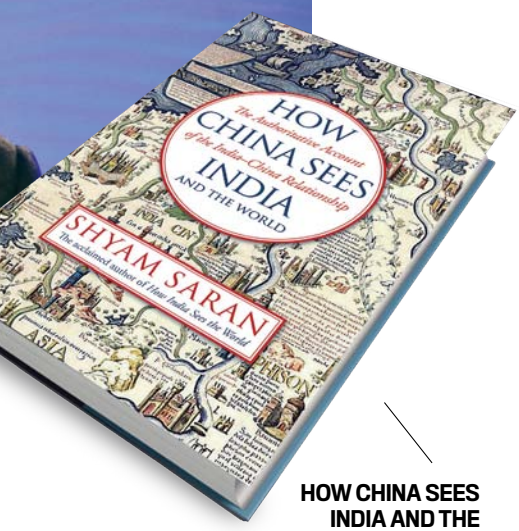


HOW CHINA SEES INDIA AND THE WORLD
by Shyam Saran
JUGGERNAUT
₹799; 304 pages

ON WHETHER THE CHINESE SYSTEM WILL LEAD TO AN ASIAN AND GLOBAL ORDER MARKED BY CHINESE HEGEMONY, SARAN IS SCEPTICAL

encounters with China during the so-called "century of humiliation", lends even greater force to his scrupulous decoupling of might and right in the Chinese story. Saran is unsparing in his analysis of Chinese perceptions of India as a "teacher by negative example"—particularly the image that "took hold during the British colonial period", when Indian merchants sat athwart the opium trade and Indian soldiers sacked the Summer Palace—and how it informs Chinese fears that India could again become "the platform for an assault" from the US.

The later chapters of the book trace China's transition from student of the West to the assessment by contemporary Chinese leaders that the US and its allies are "still dangerous, but already in terminal decline". After struggling for over a century with the question of whether the West's more advanced "practical techniques" could be separated from its political ideas, Chinese officials now present the Chinese system as superior, and even—with all its peculiarities—as a model to follow.

The critical question Saran addresses is whether this will ultimately translate into an Asian and global order characterised by Chinese hegemony. Here he is sceptical. Chinese president Xi Jinping's ideological turn—including the seeming belief that it is the party's leadership and its Leninist model that lies at the root of China's success—has already started to choke off the real drivers of Chinese growth: its dynamic private sector and its openness to the rest of the world. China was already facing structural economic challenges; Xi has made them worse. Leninist systems invariably face difficulties in managing orderly power transitions; Xi has made this problem harder by ignoring the term limits and "warnings against the rise of a personality cult" that Deng Xiaoping had put in place. India's resilience and future success will not, Saran suggests, lie in emulating this model.

China is also emerging in a context where Asia and the world at large are home to a number of other powers, old and new, that have little inclination to defer to Sino-centricity, and have the means to ensure that it is kept in check. The "arrogance" and "hubris" with which Xi has been wielding its newfound power has only expedited what Saran characterises as "the nightmare of countervailing coalitions". Even if China becomes the most powerful country, its capacity to achieve a hegemonic position that replaces the western order is doubtful.

Sinologists are often tempted to offer either reductive "all you need to know" simplifications or mandarin "you cannot possibly hope to know what we know" complexity. Saran instead provides breadth, balance and clinical judgement. For anyone looking to make sense of the power that China has become and what it means for the world, his book is an excellent place to start. ■

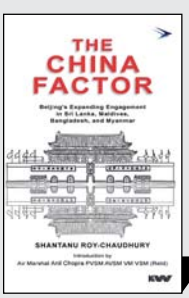
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UNDERSTANDING THE INDIA CHINA BORDER
The Enduring Threat of War in the High Himalayas
by Manoj Joshi
HARPERCOLLINS
₹599; 312 pages

A nuanced examination of the frictions along the world's longest disputed frontier. Offering a detailed account of diplomacy, events on the ground, as well as some sharp analysis of the motives that have kept the border on the boil from Doklam to Galwan.

THE CHINA FACTOR: Beijing's Expanding Engagement in Sri Lanka, Maldives, Bangladesh and Myanmar
by Shantanu Roy-Chaudhury
KW PUBLISHERS
₹1,480; 394 pgs



Examining the challenges India faces in its own backyard. China's geo-political investment here will increase, the author warns, and India must engage with the 'highly probable, high impact threat' of what he terms a 'Gray Rhino' (as opposed to Black Swan) situation.